



SoftStart

Money Reset Journal

*A gentle space to explore your relationship with money —
without shame, without judgment, without pressure.*

This journal belongs to:

I'm starting on:

There is no right way to use this journal. Just begin where you are.





A Note For You

If you're holding this journal, something in you was ready.

Maybe you've been avoiding your finances for a while. Maybe the thought of looking at your bank account makes your stomach hurt. Maybe you've tried to budget before and it didn't stick — and somewhere along the way you decided that meant something was wrong with you.

It doesn't.

Avoiding money isn't a character flaw. It's a response. When something feels overwhelming or tied to shame, our minds protect us by looking away. That's not weakness. That's being human.

This journal isn't here to fix you. You're not broken.

It's here to help you get curious about your relationship with money — gently, honestly, and without pressure. There are no wrong answers. There is no grade. Nobody is watching.

Just you, a pen, and a soft place to start.

Take your time. Skip sections that feel too heavy and come back to them. Write messy. Cross things out. Use this however it works for you.

The only rule is this: be as kind to yourself on these pages as you would be to a dear friend who was going through the same thing.

You deserve that kindness. Especially here.

— *With grace, the SoftStart team*



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Section 01

My Spending Story

Spending is almost never just about money. Behind every purchase is a feeling, a need, or a story we're telling ourselves. This section invites you to get curious — not critical — about what was really going on.

"I am allowed to look at my choices with curiosity, not shame."

Think of a recent purchase you regret or feel confused about.

What did you buy? Where were you? What was happening in your life that day?

What were you feeling right before you bought it?

Bored? Stressed? Lonely? Excited? Trying to reward yourself? Just honest here — no judgment.

What did you hope it would give you?

Relief? Happiness? A sense of control? Something to look forward to?



Looking back, what did you actually need in that moment?

What would have truly helped?





My Spending Story • continued

Is there a pattern you're starting to notice?

Certain times of day, days of the week, or emotional states that trigger spending?

What would you tell a close friend who was in this same situation?

Write it here — then read it back to yourself.



Section 02

Spending Triggers Map

We all have emotional triggers that lead us to spend. Understanding yours isn't about beating yourself up — it's about building awareness so you can make a different choice next time.

"Awareness is the first step to change. I am paying attention."

Boredom Spending

I spend when I have nothing to do, or when life feels flat and uninspiring.

■ This is me

Stress Spending

I spend when I'm overwhelmed, anxious, or trying to escape a hard feeling.

■ This is me

Reward Spending

I spend to celebrate or treat myself — often after working hard or going through something difficult.

■ This is me

Social Spending

I spend to keep up, fit in, or avoid the discomfort of saying no to people I care about.

■ This is me

Sadness Spending

I spend when I'm lonely, grieving, or feeling low — hoping something new will lift my mood.

■ This is me

Avoidance Spending

I spend instead of dealing with something else I'm avoiding — a conversation, a decision, a feeling.

■ This is me

My biggest trigger is:

Describe a specific moment when this trigger showed up for you.



Next time I feel this trigger, I could try:

What's one small thing you could do instead of spending?





Section 03

Money Mindset

Our relationship with money starts long before we earn our first dollar. The things we heard, saw, and felt about money growing up shape how we handle it today — often without us even realizing it.

"My past shaped me, but it does not define what's possible for me now."

What did money mean in the home you grew up in?

Was it talked about openly or kept secret? Was there enough? What was the feeling around it?

What messages did you receive about money as a child?

Think about things that were said — or never said. Things you observed. Things you felt.

Which of those messages are you still carrying today?

Which ones no longer serve you?









Money Mindset • continued

Complete this sentence:

"Money is _____" — write the first thing that comes to mind. Then ask yourself: where did that belief come from?

What would you like to believe about money instead?

Write a new belief — even if it doesn't feel true yet. Write it as if it already is.



Section 04

Money Identity

Who are you becoming with money? Not who you've been — who you're deciding to be. Identity shapes behavior more than willpower ever will. When you know who you're becoming, the small daily choices start to make sense.

"I am becoming someone who takes care of herself financially."

How would you describe your current relationship with money?

Be honest — this is just for you.

Describe the version of you who has her money together.

How does she feel? What does she do differently? How does she carry herself?

What's one small thing the future version of you does that you could start doing today?

Even something tiny counts.



Complete this sentence:

"I am a woman who _____" (finish it with something true about your money identity — even if you're still becoming her).



Section 05

Financial Boundaries

Money and relationships are complicated. Lending money, social pressure, family expectations — these can quietly drain both your finances and your peace. This section helps you get clear on where you stand.

"I am allowed to protect my financial peace."

Has money ever caused tension in a relationship?

What happened? How did it make you feel?

Do you find it hard to say no to spending when others are involved?

Think about social outings, lending money, family requests, keeping up with others.

What boundary would protect your financial peace right now?

It could be with a person, a habit, or even yourself.



Practice saying it here:

Write out how you would explain this boundary kindly but clearly.



Section 06

Financial Wins

We are wired to notice what's wrong. This section is intentionally dedicated to what's right. Every step forward counts — even the ones that feel small. Especially those.

"Every good choice I make is worth celebrating."

List every financial win you can think of — big or small.

Paid a bill on time. Said no to something you didn't need. Checked your account instead of avoiding it. Cooked at home. Anything counts.

My biggest financial win so far has been:

How did it make you feel? What did it take to get there?

The win I'm most proud of (even if others might not understand why):





Section 07

Weekly Reflection

Consistency builds confidence. This section gives you a gentle weekly check-in to look back without judgment and look forward with intention. Use one page per week.

"I show up for myself, one week at a time."

Week 1

This week I noticed about my spending:

Something I did well this week:

Something I want to do differently next week:

How I'm feeling about money right now:

Week 2

This week I noticed about my spending:



Something I did well this week:

Something I want to do differently next week:

How I'm feeling about money right now:

Week 3

This week I noticed about my spending:

Something I did well this week:

Something I want to do differently next week:

How I'm feeling about money right now:





Week 4

This week I noticed about my spending:

Something I did well this week:

Something I want to do differently next week:

How I'm feeling about money right now:





You Showed Up.

That matters more than you know.

Working through this journal means you chose yourself. You chose honesty over avoidance, curiosity over shame, and a soft start over no start at all.

That is not a small thing.

Your money story isn't finished. It's being rewritten — one honest page, one small choice, one gentle week at a time.

Keep going.

Ready for the next step? Your Soft Start Budget tool is waiting.

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